

THE SYSTEM.

Bible 1.0 taught you **what** a good video is. This one exists to get videos **finished** — the 14-day loop, the head game against perfectionism, and the taste calls that make gaming videos actually fun to watch and actually fun to make.



REC ●

FORMAT

Companion to Bible 1.0

BUILT AROUND

1 video / 2 weeks

RESEARCH WINDOW

2023 – 2026, verified

How this book works

Two bibles, two jobs. Zero overlap on purpose.

Bible 1.0 is the reference shelf: title formulas, the 8 packages, thumbnail rules, checklists, creator frameworks. It answers *"what does a good video look like?"*

Bible 2.0 — this one — is the operating system. It answers the question 1.0 can't: *"how do I actually get myself through it, every two weeks, without perfectionism or avoidance eating the video alive?"* When this book needs a formula, it points at 1.0 with a chip that looks like this: ↗ 1.0 §13 . Keep both on your phone.

HOW TO READ IT

- ▶ **Part 1 — read once, fully.** It's the head game: perfectionism, the "lazy" myth, and how to make the process addicting. Everything else is built on it.
- ▶ **Part 2 — live in it.** The 14-day loop is the actual system. You'll reread stations mid-loop constantly. That's the point.
- ▶ **Parts 3–5 — visit when the question comes up.** What makes a video good, how multi-game works, which tools deserve your time.
- ▶ **Part 6 — open in emergencies only.** Five one-page cards for the five ways this actually goes wrong. Big type, short steps, written for the bad days.

THE ONE-SENTENCE PHILOSOPHY

You are not building videos. You are building a loop that produces videos.

Any single video is allowed to be mid. The loop is not allowed to stop. Protect the loop and the videos take care of themselves — that's what "one small improvement at a time" actually means in practice.

WHEN YOU NEED...	GO TO
Title formulas & patterns	1.0 §13
Thumbnail 3 C's + Affinity workflow	1.0 §14
The 8 packages & pre-record questions	1.0 §8–9
Hook formula & re-hook lines	1.0 §15
Marker colors, export settings, checklists	1.0 §17, §20, §31–35
Getting yourself to actually do any of the above	THIS BOOK

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Tap any line — the whole book is linked.

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PART 1 / 6

THE HEAD GAME

Every skipped editing session, every idea that died in your notes app, every "why would anyone watch this" — none of it is a talent problem. It's six specific mental bugs, and every one of them has a patch.

§01 THE QUESTION · §02 THE SLOP MATH · §03 THE CRINGE CLAUSE · §04 "LAZY," DECODED
· §05 THE ADDICTION LOOP · §06 THE B+ STANDARD



The question that's killing your videos

"Why would anyone watch this?" feels like quality control. It's actually a wrecking ball.

Here's the problem with that question: **it has no answer**. Not for you, not for anyone. Channels with a hundred employees and a decade of data still can't predict which video hits — that's why they A/B test thumbnails instead of just *knowing*. If the biggest operations on the platform can't answer "will people watch this?" before upload, you asking it at midnight over an unedited timeline isn't quality control. It's asking the universe for a guarantee the universe doesn't sell.

And an unanswerable question doesn't filter *bad* ideas. It filters **all** ideas — because every idea fails a test that can't be passed. That's how a perfectionist ends up with a notes app full of concepts and an upload page with nothing on it.

THE REPLACEMENT QUESTION

"Would I click this if someone else posted it?"

Same test as Bible 1.0's excitement check [↗ 1.0 §1.5](#) — and unlike the killer question, this one is answerable in five seconds, by you, right now. A yes doesn't mean the video is guaranteed. It means the idea has earned *a recording session*. That's all any idea can earn before it exists. Everything past that point is only knowable in public.

What perfectionism actually is

Perfectionism markets itself as high standards. It isn't. **High standards ship the video, read the retention graph, and make the next one better**. Perfectionism polishes the same twenty seconds for the third time so it never has to find out what the world thinks. One is a quality process. The other is fear wearing a productivity costume — it *feels* like working hard, which is exactly why it's so effective at stopping you.

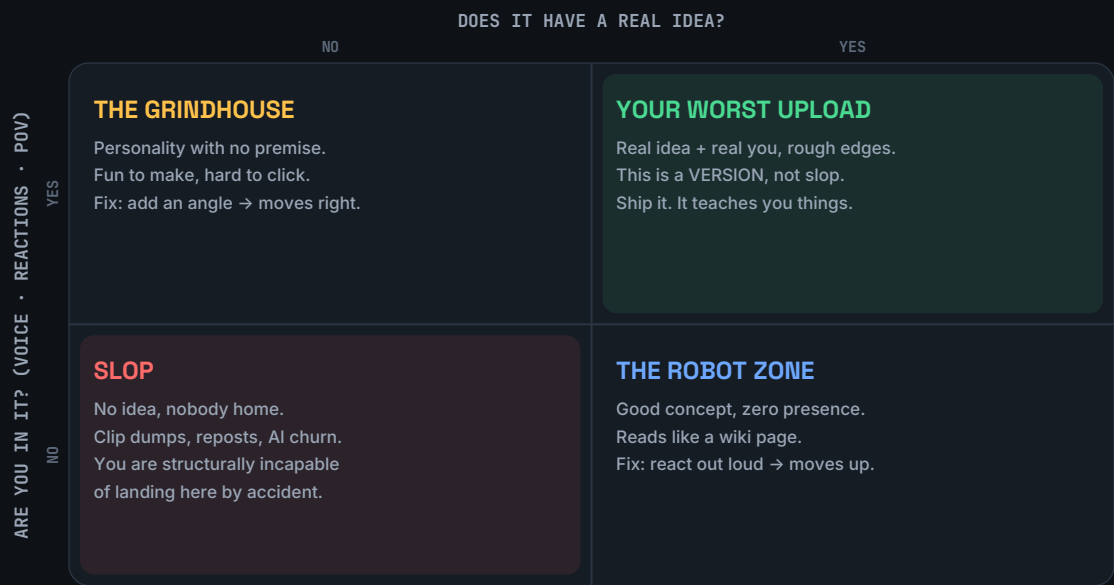
The tell is simple: **standards move you forward through the pipeline; perfectionism moves you in circles inside one step**. If you catch yourself circling — re-trimming a cut that was fine an hour ago, rewriting a title for the ninth time — you're not raising quality anymore. You're avoiding the scary next step. Name it, and move to the next station anyway. The system in Part 2 is built so there is *always* a next station.

DO THIS WHEN THE KILLER QUESTION SHOWS UP: SAY "UNANSWERABLE," ASK THE CLICK QUESTION INSTEAD, AND KEEP MOVING.

The slop math

You said you don't want to upload slop. Good news: slop has a definition, and you're nowhere near it.

Fear thrives on vagueness. "I don't want to upload slop" is scary precisely because *slop* is undefined — so every rough edit feels like it might secretly qualify. So let's define it. **Slop is content with no idea and nobody home:** reposted clip dumps, context-free gameplay uploads, mass-produced AI churn. YouTube itself drew this line — its July 2025 monetization update targets exactly that "inauthentic," repetitious, mass-produced content, while explicitly protecting original videos with real human input. The platform's official slop line and your worst possible upload aren't even in the same neighborhood.



YOUTUBE'S JULY 2025 MONETIZATION UPDATE DREW THE OFFICIAL LINE AT "INAUTHENTIC" MASS-PRODUCED, REPETITIOUS CONTENT — THE BOTTOM-LEFT BOX. A ROUGH EDIT OF A REAL IDEA WITH YOUR REAL REACTIONS ISN'T NEAR IT.

FIG 02 — THE SLOP MAP. TWO QUESTIONS SORT EVERYTHING: IS THERE A REAL IDEA, AND ARE YOU IN IT?

A rough edit of a real premise with your genuine reactions isn't slop — **it's a version**. Version 3 of your channel will embarrass version 12. That's not a flaw in the plan. That *is* the plan.

The reps come first — this is the actual expert consensus

"In the beginning, you need to get reps of doing a whole video — so you at least experience and start building the muscle memory of all these different moving parts."

— THE CONSENSUS PADDY GALLOWAY (STRATEGIST BEHIND SOME OF YOUTUBE'S BIGGEST CHANNELS) AGREED TO ON CREATOR SCIENCE, 2024

Notice what the most-hired strategist on the platform prescribes for your stage: not better videos — **whole videos, repeatedly**. A video is a stack of maybe fifteen skills (idea, title, hook, pacing, cuts, sound, thumbnail...), and the only way to level any of them is full runs through the stack. MrBeast's version of the same idea is already in Bible 1.0 ↗ **1.0 §7** : every video is a data point, not a report card.

THE UNCOMFORTABLE MATH THAT SETS YOU FREE

Almost nobody is watching your early uploads — which means almost nobody is watching your early uploads' *flaws* either. The judgment you're bracing for has an audience of roughly zero. Early videos aren't your portfolio; they're your tuition. The stakes you feel are imaginary, and imaginary stakes are the only kind you're allowed to ignore.

DO THIS BEFORE CALLING ANYTHING "SLOP," CHECK THE MAP: REAL IDEA? YOU IN IT? THEN IT'S A VERSION. SHIP THE VERSION.

The cringe clause

You will cringe at your early videos. This is not a risk. It's the receipt.

There's a famous idea from radio host Ira Glass that every creative eventually rediscovers the hard way: when you start, **your taste is years ahead of your skill**. You can already *see* what a great gaming video looks like — you've watched thousands. You just can't *make* one yet. That gap is why your own work disappoints you, and Glass's point is that the gap closes exactly one way: **a large volume of finished work**. Not perfect work. Finished work.

So flip what cringe means. Cringing at video #4 while making video #20 is proof your taste kept growing — the exact signal you're improving. The only creators who never cringe at their archive are the ones who never built one.

THE CLAUSE — TWO RULES

- ▶ **You're allowed to cringe. You're not allowed to delete.** Early videos are the before-photo; the whole story of a channel needs its first chapter. (After 20+ uploads, unlisting a few is fine. Before that, the archive stands.)
- ▶ **Future cringe cannot veto present uploads.** "I'll be embarrassed by this in a year" is true of everything you'll ever make, forever — including the video you'd make instead after six more months of polishing. It's not information. It's the toll.

The rewiring exercise (10 minutes, once)

Pick two or three creators you genuinely rate. Sort their channel by *oldest*. Watch two minutes of their first uploads — the muddy mics, the dead air, the titles that promise nothing. It's one thing to be told "everyone starts rough" and a very different thing to *watch* your heroes start rough. Ten minutes of this permanently reprices what video #1 is supposed to look like.

DO THIS RUN THE OLDEST-VIDEO EXERCISE ONCE THIS WEEK. THEN NEVER USE FUTURE CRINGE AS A REASON AGAIN.

"Lazy," decoded

A person who streams on a schedule, wired a six-track OBS setup, and built a production bible is not lazy. Something more specific is happening.

"I'm lazy" is a diagnosis that explains nothing and fixes nothing — which is why it never leads anywhere except feeling bad. What actually stalls you is almost always one of three *solvable* problems, and they need different fixes, so it pays to know which one you're staring at:

THE BUG	WHAT IT FEELS LIKE	THE ACTUAL FIX
FRICITION	Starting takes 12 steps — find the footage, open the project, remember where you were. You bounce off before you begin.	Kill the steps once, permanently ↗ §26
FOG	"Edit the video" sits on the to-do list for days. Brains refuse vague projects; they only execute concrete tasks.	Never face anything bigger than one named block ↗ §05
FEAR	Suspiciously productive at everything <i>except</i> the video. Avoidance protects you from judgment — see §01.	The B+ standard makes "done" reachable ↗ §06

And sometimes the answer is a fourth thing: **you're actually tired**. Streams, school, life — real fatigue is real, and pushing a block through genuine exhaustion produces garbage and resentment. Rest is a valid move inside the loop. Guilt is the only move with no function at all.

The ignition rule

You already proved this to yourself: **momentum precedes motivation**. Waiting to feel like editing is backwards — the feeling shows up a few minutes *after* starting, not before. So you never negotiate with "do I feel like editing tonight?" That question loses. You negotiate with a much smaller one:



FIG 04 — THE 10-MINUTE DEAL. BOTH EXITS FILL THE CELL. THE STREAK TRACKS SHOWING UP, NOT HEROICS.

Ten minutes, timer on, full legal permission to stop when it rings. Most nights, momentum carries you well past it — starting was the entire boss fight. The nights you genuinely stop at ten? The streak survives, the project moved, and tomorrow's start is easier because today's happened. There is no losing exit.

DO THIS RETIRE THE WORD "LAZY." DIAGNOSE INSTEAD: FRICTION, FOG, FEAR, OR TIRED – THEN RUN THAT FIX.

The addiction loop

You asked for the process to be addicting. Addicting is an engineering spec — here's the build.

Games are addicting for reasons game designers understand precisely: **a clear current objective, visible progress, immediate feedback, and streaks**. Default editing has none of those — invisible progress, vague objectives ("finish the video"...), and feedback that arrives two weeks later as a retention graph. Of course the game wins every night. The fix isn't discipline. The fix is installing the game's loop onto the work:



FIG 05 — CUE → TINY START → VISIBLE PROGRESS → REWARD. RUN IT DAILY AND THE PROCESS STARTS PULLING YOU BACK.

The four installs

- 01 THE BLOCK — your XP unit.** 25–45 minutes, one named objective: "rough cut minutes 0–4," "SFX pass on act two," "three title options." A block is small enough to start on a bad day and concrete enough that your brain can't refuse it. All planning in this book is denominated in blocks, never in "days of work."
- 02 THE QUEST LOG — never end without the next quest.** Before closing Resolve, write one line: the next block's objective. Ninety seconds. This is the highest-leverage habit in the entire book, because it deletes the worst moment in editing — opening the project cold and spending twenty minutes figuring out where you were. Future-you spawns with an active quest marker.
- 03 THE TRACKER — progress you can see.** Humans finish bars they can watch fill. The back of this book has a first-ten grid [↗ §33](#) ; fill one cell per block, in Notion or on paper. Filling the cell is the point — it converts invisible work into a visible number going up, which is the exact mechanic every simulator game runs on you.
- 04 THE REWARD — end on your best 20 seconds.** Close every session by watching the funniest or cleanest moment you touched today, once, at full volume. Sessions that end on the good part get returned to. Sessions that end mid-slog get avoided. You're programming tomorrow's craving tonight.

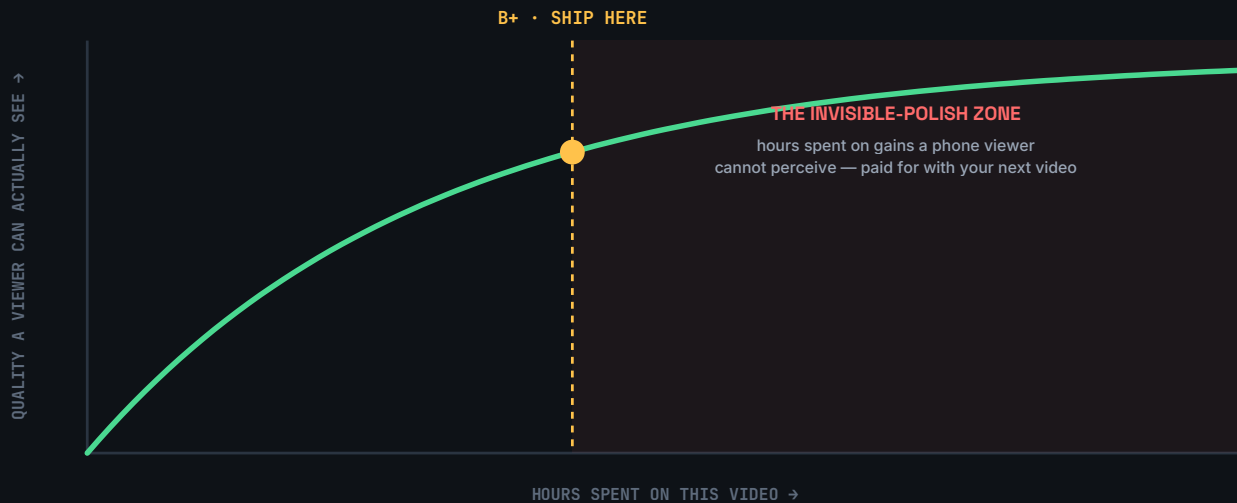
THE STREAK RULE (STOLEN FROM HABIT SCIENCE)

One block a day keeps the streak — any block, even a 10-minute one. And the real rule is: never miss twice. One missed day is noise; life happens. Two in a row is a new habit forming in the wrong direction. So the day after a miss, the only job is the smallest possible block. Not a comeback. A block.

DO THIS TONIGHT: WRITE TOMORROW'S QUEST LINE FOR WHATEVER PROJECT IS OPEN. THAT'S THE WHOLE INSTALL.

The B+ standard

If you don't define "done," perfectionism will define it for you — as "never."



B+ ≥ PREMISE CLEAR IN 30s • DEAD AIR GONE • AUDIO BALANCED • 3+ MOMENTS THAT GET A REACTION • PACKAGING PASSES THE GLANCE TEST.

FIG 06 — THE CURVE EVERY EDITOR LEARNS EVENTUALLY. AFTER B+, HOURS BUY POLISH A PHONE VIEWER CANNOT PERCEIVE.

Quality per hour is brutal math: the first hours of an edit create almost all the value a viewer can actually detect — story structure, dead air gone, reactions landing. Past a point, each extra hour buys refinements that are **literally invisible on a phone screen with phone speakers at 1x speed**, which is where most of your audience lives. But those invisible hours have a very visible cost: they're stolen from the next video. And at your stage, the next video — the next full rep — is worth more than the last 5% of this one. Every time.

B+ , DEFINED — THE SHIPPING CHECKLIST

- ▶ The premise is unmistakable inside 30 seconds.
- ▶ Dead air and dead sections are gone — the boring test passed [↗ §11](#) .
- ▶ Audio is balanced to targets, one full playback confirmed no disasters [↗ §12](#) .
- ▶ At least three moments still get a reaction out of *you* — on your fifteenth viewing.
- ▶ Title + thumbnail pass the glance test and tell one story [↗ 1.0 §13-14](#) .

Hit all five → the video ships. Not "ships if you feel good about it." Ships.

What B+ deliberately excludes

Perfect color on every clip. Invisible-cut smoothness nobody consciously registers. An effect on every joke. The fourth full rewatch. Re-exporting because one transition is 3 frames long. These aren't quality — they're anxiety with a render queue. And here's the kicker from the top of the mountain: MrBeast's own public pivot [↗ §17](#) was away from maximal edit density, toward personality and letting scenes breathe — meaning the thing perfectionism wants you to add more of wasn't the growth lever *even for the biggest channel on Earth*.

THE ONE-WATCH RULE

You get **one** full final playback (it's already in the 1.0 editing checklist). Fix what actually breaks — a clipped peak, a missing caption, a cut that kills a joke. Then export. When the urge for pass #4 arrives — and it will — you don't have to obey it. Notice it, name it ("that's the fear, not the standards"), and press export anyway. That press is the rep that matters most.

DO THIS SCREENSHOT THE B+ CHECKLIST. IT IS NOW THE ONLY DEFINITION OF "DONE" THAT EXISTS.

THE 14-DAY LOOP

Six stations, two built-in slack days, one video every two weeks. Long enough that nothing is ever rushed. Short enough that the heat never dies. Small enough to run alongside streams, school, and an actual life.

§07 THE MAP · §08 DECIDE · §09 RECORD · §10 TRIAGE · §11 STORY CUT · §12 ENERGY · §13 SHIP · §14 RESET · §15 BREAKAGE

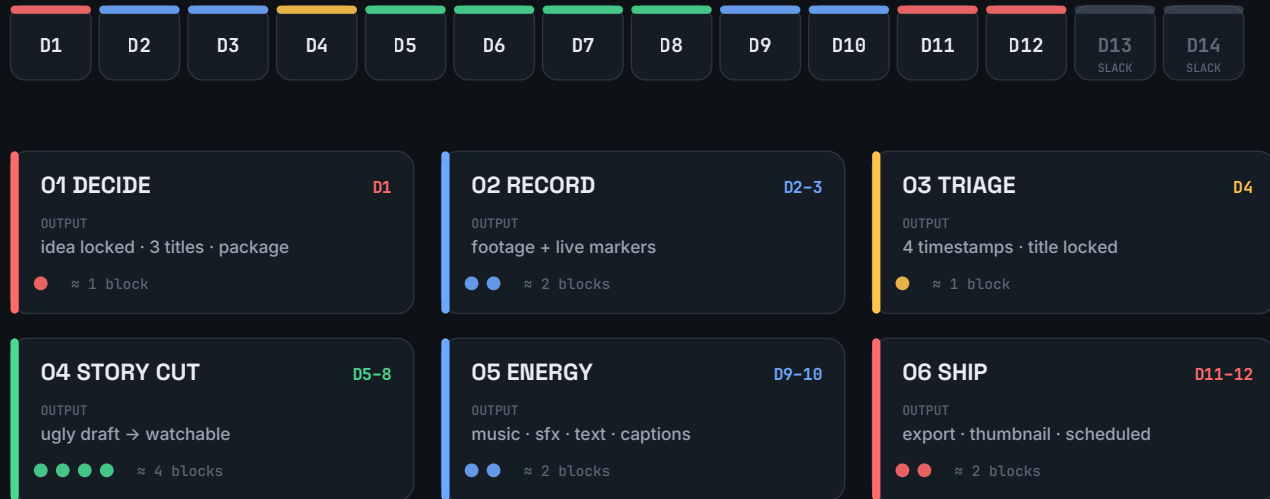


The loop, mapped

One picture to hold the whole system. Everything after this page is just zooming in.

THE 14-DAY LOOP

1 VIDEO / 2 WEEKS · BLOCKS, NOT MARATHONS



A BLOCK = 25-45 MIN WITH ONE NAMED OBJECTIVE. A STATION MIGHT TAKE 1 BLOCK OR 4 — THE DAY LABELS ARE A MAP, NOT A CAGE.

FIG 07 — SIX STATIONS ACROSS FOURTEEN DAYS, ≈ 12 BLOCKS TOTAL. DAYS ARE THE MAP; BLOCKS ARE THE TERRITORY.

The five laws of the loop

- 01 Stations run in order.** Each one exists to make the next one easier. Deciding before recording makes the footage aimable; triaging before cutting makes the edit findable. Skipping ahead always costs more than it saves [↗ §15](#).
- 02 Blocks are the unit, days are the label.** "D5-8: Story Cut" doesn't mean four full days of editing — it means roughly four 25-45 minute blocks spread across that window. A light week might do a station in one sitting; a heavy week spreads it thin. Both are the loop working.
- 03 Slack is load-bearing.** D13-14 exist so a busy Tuesday doesn't shatter the system. A schedule with zero slack breaks on first contact with real life; a schedule with slack bends and keeps going. Don't fill the slack days "to get ahead." They're shock absorbers, not spare capacity.
- 04 Streams feed the loop for free.** Your streaming schedule doesn't change. A stream session with a declared premise *is* Station 2 — the loop just harvests it. One system, not two competing ones.
- 05 The loop overlaps itself.** While this video moves through stations, the *previous* upload's 48-hour data arrives — which is exactly what the Reset reviews on D13-14. Ship one, learn from the last, decide the next. That's the flywheel.

WHY 14 DAYS SPECIFICALLY

Weekly uploads at your stage force rushing, and rushing is where perfectionists spiral (no time to do it "right" → do nothing). Monthly kills momentum — by week three the project feels like homework from a past life. Fourteen days is the pocket: every video gets real care, and you still bank **26 full reps a year** — which, per §02, is the only thing that actually levels you up. Consistency beats frequency; a schedule you can keep beats a schedule that sounds impressive ↗ 1.0 §6 .

Station 1 — DECIDE

One block. A timer. You leave with a title written down — or you don't leave.

This station is where the research says the entire game is won, and where almost every small creator spends almost no time. Paddy Galloway's channel audits keep finding the same split: small channels put roughly **95% of their effort into filming and editing and ~5% into the idea and packaging** — while the top channels he works with allocate around **30% to ideation and packaging**. His favorite proof: an astrophotography creator stuck at 2–3K views who reallocated effort toward titles and thumbnails and jumped past a million. Same footage quality. Different Station 1.

The beautiful part for you: reallocating like the top channels costs exactly **one block per loop**. Here's the block:

- 01 Pull candidates (10 min).** Open the idea bank — stream moments you captured, autocomplete finds, "what if" restrictions ↗ 1.0 §1.5 . No bank? Spend the ten minutes running the generators on whatever game is next in rotation.
- 02 Run the 3-yes test on the top two only (5 min).** Title that excites you? Thumbnail describable in one sentence? Do you know what "the end" looks like? Two candidates max — comparing five is how deciding becomes a week.
- 03 Write 3 title options + the thumbnail sentence (10 min).** Before any recording exists. Title-first is the single most repeated piece of advice across every framework in Bible 1.0, because it forces the video to be an actual promise instead of a session ↗ 1.0 §4, §13 .
- 04 Pick bucket + package (2 min).** The 30-second decision tree ↗ 1.0 §9 . Write the one intro line. Done — close the laptop if you want. Station complete.

FAILURE MODES, PRE-SOLVED

- ▶ **Nothing passes 3 yeses** → sharpen, don't abandon: add a restriction, a timer, or a consequence and re-test. Two sharpening passes fix most "meh" ideas ↗ 1.0 §1.5 .
- ▶ **Still nothing** → schedule a Discovery or Commentary Run on something new and mine it afterward. Recording generates ideas; waiting for ideas generates waiting.
- ▶ **Deciding is taking days** → that's §01 in disguise. The timer is the treatment: when it rings, the leading candidate wins. A shipped B-idea beats an unshipped A-idea by exactly one video.

STATION EXIT A LOCKED PREMISE, 3 TITLES, A THUMBNAIL SENTENCE, A PACKAGE, AN INTRO LINE. 30–40 MINUTES, TOTAL.

Station 2 — RECORD

The station you're already good at. The job here is protecting it from the stations around it.

- 01 **Preflight, five minutes.** The recording checklist [↗ 1.0 §32](#) : OBS profile, test clip, levels, intro line in your head — not on a script. Then hit record and say *the line*. The intro is the only scripted sentence in the whole video; everything after is play.
- 02 **Play with the three anchors idling in the background.** Mission (say the current goal out loud), Tension (narrate what failure costs), Moment (when something's happening — lean in, react bigger) [↗ 1.0 §10](#) . Don't perform. Just don't swallow reactions; they're the product.
- 03 **Flag in real time.** Hotkey markers on the big beats — best moment, interesting, Shorts-worthy, thumbnail face. Ten seconds of flagging mid-session saves an hour of scrubbing at Station 3. Your future self is the audience for these markers; be generous to them.
- 04 **End hot.** The moment the session ends, voice-note the 2–3 best moments while they're fresh. The immediate hot take about what was funny is almost always right, and it evaporates by morning [↗ 1.0 §27](#) .

The two rules that protect the footage

RULE 1 — NO MID-SESSION JUDGING

"Is this any good?" is Station 3's question. Asking it while recording splits your attention, kills your energy on camera, and — worst — tempts you to stop a session that was two minutes from its best moment. While recording, your only job is to be *in it*. Verdicts come later, at 2x speed, with markers.

RULE 2 — A BAD SESSION IS A GENRE, NOT A FAILURE

Plan collapsing? Keep rolling. Things going catastrophically wrong *is* a premise — the Downfall and Disaster packages exist because failure with genuine reactions routinely outperforms success with mild ones [↗ 1.0 §13, §24](#) . The only genuinely unusable session is the one you stopped recording. In co-op, same energy: don't over-brief, don't micromanage — confusion between players is organic comedy you can't script [↗ 1.0 §26](#) .

STATION EXIT FOOTAGE WITH LIVE MARKERS + A HOT-TAKE VOICE NOTE. THAT'S IT — RESIST TOUCHING RESOLVE TONIGHT.

Station 3 — TRIAGE

The no-edit watch. Hands off the blade — this block is eyes only.

- 01 **Watch everything at 1.5–2x.** One pass, start to finish, blade tool untouched. You're not editing; you're scouting. Cutting while scouting is how three-hour sessions produce four minutes of timeline and total exhaustion.
- 02 **Mark the four timestamps.** BEST · FUNNIEST · TENSION PEAK · GOOD INTRO — with the marker colors doing their jobs (red must-use, blue story beat, green Shorts, yellow maybe) ↗ 1.0 §11, §17 . These four timestamps are the video's skeleton. Everything at Station 4 is connective tissue between them.
- 03 **Lock the title — now, before any cut.** Take your three options from Station 1 and pick, upgraded by what actually happened. Footage-informed titles beat pre-recording guesses, and a locked title is the edit's north star: every clip either serves the promise or gets cut. Update the thumbnail sentence to match.
- 04 **Say the story sentence.** Exit test: "It's the one where ____." If you can finish that sentence, you have a video. If you can't, you haven't chosen the peak yet — go back to your red markers, pick the single best moment, and build the sentence around it. Do not proceed to Station 4 without the sentence; cutting without it is wandering.

WHY THIS STATION EXISTS AT ALL

Perfectionists drown at Station 4 because they arrive with no map — every clip is a fresh decision, every decision invites second-guessing, and the timeline becomes quicksand. Triage converts an open-ended creative ordeal into a connect-the-dots exercise: four fixed points, one promise, cut toward them. It's the single cheapest hour in the whole pipeline for how much pain it deletes.

STATION EXIT 4 TIMESTAMPS · MARKER PASS DONE · TITLE LOCKED · "IT'S THE ONE WHERE ___" ANSWERED OUT LOUD.

Station 4 — STORY CUT

The ugly draft. Structure only. Polish is banned on this station — by law.

- 01 **Best moment to the front.** Your red-marked peak (or a fast taste of it) opens the timeline; the story of getting there follows [↗ 1.0 §7, §11](#) . Show them the payoff is worth staying for, then earn it.
- 02 **Cut toward the four timestamps.** Everything that serves the peak or its setup stays. Everything else — the wandering, the menus, the third similar fail — goes. Ripple delete is the most-used key on this station by a mile.
- 03 **No polish. None.** No SFX, no color, no text, no transitions. Polishing an unlocked structure is painting a wall you might demolish tomorrow — every effect you add makes a clip emotionally harder to cut, which quietly corrupts your structural judgment. Naked timeline until the story locks.
- 04 **Blocks with named quests.** "Rough cut 0:00–4:00." "Tighten act two." Never "work on the video." Each block ends with the quest-log line for the next one [↗ §05](#) .
- 05 **The boring test.** When the rough is assembled, watch it once at 1x. Any section that bores *you* — the person who lived it and has seen it five times — dies. You cannot bore a stranger into retention. Be ruthless; a shorter alive video beats a longer complete one every single time.

IF THE WHOLE ROUGH FEELS DEAD

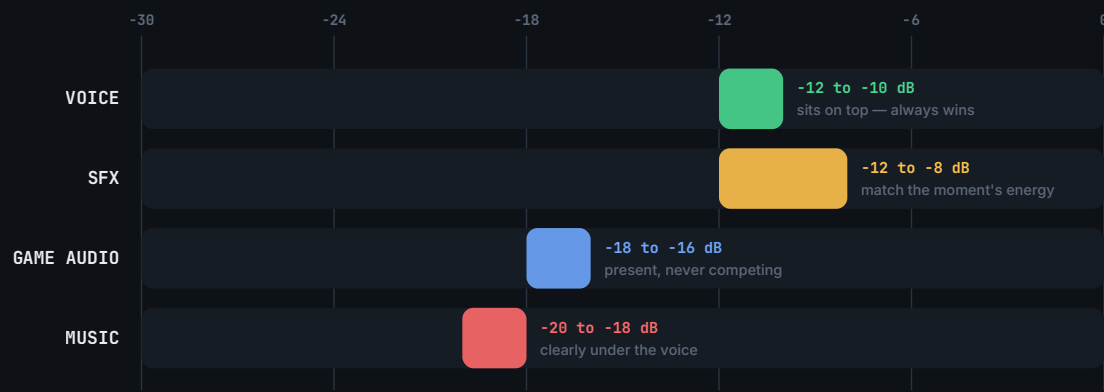
Do **not** respond with polish — energy passes cannot resurrect a structural corpse. Restructure instead: move the peak earlier, compress the setup, or **re-angle** — the video about the plan becomes the video about the plan falling apart (often the stronger video anyway). Structural surgery is cheap at this station and agonizing after SFX are glued on. And if doubt is whispering "just abandon it" — that's Card 2 [↗ §28](#) . Read it before deciding anything.

STATION EXIT A WATCHABLE-BUT-NAKED ROUGH CUT THAT PASSES THE BORING TEST. STRUCTURE LOCKED.

Station 5 — ENERGY

Music, sound, text, captions — in that exact order, as separate passes. Never interleaved.

- 01 **Music pass first.** Music sets the emotional temperature of everything sitting on top of it — the same joke reads different on a goofy bed versus silence, which is why it goes down before any SFX decisions get made ↗ 1.0 §11 . Pull from your organized folders, place by mood per act, and pre-plan one *music drop-out* at the biggest moment (see §18 — silence is the best effect you own).
- 02 **SFX pass.** Punctuation on moments that earned it — the doctrine and the core kit live in §18. If a sound doesn't make a specific moment land harder, it doesn't go in.
- 03 **Text pass.** 3–5 callouts per video, max, amplifying the funniest lines ↗ 1.0 §11 . Text is seasoning; a subtitle on every sentence of commentary is a Shorts convention, not a long-form one.
- 04 **Captions.** Auto-captions via your power bin — a huge share of viewing happens muted, and captions are pure free retention.
- 05 **Audio balance.** The numbers, so this page is the only one open in Fairlight:



WHOLE-VIDEO TARGET: -14 LUFS INTEGRATED (YOUTUBE'S NORMALIZATION POINT — CHECK IN FAIRLIGHT'S LOUDNESS METER)
TRUE PEAK CEILING: -1 dBTP (ONE LIMITER ON THE MASTER BUS = INSURANCE)
SAME NUMBERS AS BIBLE 1.0 §19 — REPEATED HERE SO THE ENERGY STATION NEVER NEEDS A SECOND DOCUMENT OPEN.

FIG 12 — MIX TARGETS. VOICE WINS EVERY FIGHT; -14 LUFS INTEGRATED; ONE LIMITER AS INSURANCE.

WHY SEPARATE PASSES INSTEAD OF "FINISH EACH SCENE"

Per-scene finishing means re-deciding your music taste, SFX taste, and text taste every ninety seconds — decision fatigue on a loop, and it produces an inconsistent video (act one over-seasoned, act three abandoned). One pass per layer keeps each decision type warm, goes roughly 3x faster, and self-balances the whole video. It's also four clean quest-log blocks instead of one endless swamp.

STATION EXIT MUSIC • SFX • TEXT • CAPTIONS DONE AS FOUR PASSES; MIX ON TARGET. THE VIDEO NOW HAS A PULSE.

Station 6 — SHIP

The station where perfectionism makes its final stand. It loses to a schedule button.

- 01 **The one watch.** Full playback, headphones, 1x ↗ §06 . Fix actual breaks only. Then render — export settings are a solved problem ↗ 1.0 §20 .
- 02 **Thumbnail while it renders.** Affinity Photo, the formula: face + game moment + two-to-three bold words, glance-tested at tiny size ↗ 1.0 §14 . Render time is free thumbnail time — the machine works while you work.
- 03 **The upload block.** Final title from your three. Description line one carries the game keyword naturally; timestamps if 10+ minutes; tags; end screen ↗ 1.0 §34 . Then — **schedule** to your consistent slot. Never "publish when it feels ready."

THE DOUBT AT THE BUTTON — READ THIS AT THE BUTTON

Somewhere between render and schedule, a voice will say *"this one isn't good enough."* Here is everything true about that voice: it shows up on schedule, for every creator, at this exact station — because this is where the work stops being private. It is a fact about **where you are standing**, not about the video. And it has *zero* predictive power: creators are famously wrong in both directions — videos they doubted overperform, videos they loved flop. The only judge with actual information is the public upload.

This is why the loop uses a **schedule** button: the decision to publish was made once, calmly, at Station 1 — it does not get renegotiated nightly by the scared version of you. B+ checklist passed → scheduled → walk away. The feeling passes. The rep stays.

STATION EXIT SCHEDULED UPLOAD + THUMBNAIL LIVE. FILL THE SHIP CELL — THIS IS THE ONE THAT COUNTS DOUBLE.

The reset

Two slack days, one 20-minute ritual, and the loop eats its own tail.

D13–14 have two jobs. The first is being **empty** — the shock absorbers that make the whole schedule survivable (§07, law 3). The second is one 20-minute ritual, done whenever in the window suits you:

- 01 **Open Studio for the previous upload** — the one that's now had 48+ hours in public. Three numbers: CTR, AVD, and the retention graph's *shape*. Gaming benchmarks for context: CTR 8–12% is strong, AVD 40–50% of length is healthy ↗ 1.0 §7 — but at your stage, direction beats absolutes: better than *your* last three is a win.
- 02 **Run the diagnostic.** CTR low + retention fine → packaging problem. CTR fine + early cliff → the first 60 seconds broke the promise. Both low → concept. The chart shapes in §20's figure tell you which story you're looking at in one glance.
- 03 **Write ONE lesson.** One sentence, in Notion, attached to the next loop: "*open with the proof clip, not the setup.*" One lesson gets applied; five get admired and ignored. Twenty-six loops a year × one applied lesson each is a completely different creator by next summer — improvement at a rate grinding alone can't touch.
- 04 **Bank the next idea.** What was *the moment* from this cycle's streams? Capture it raw. Station 1 of the next loop now starts loaded instead of blank.

THEN CLOSE THE LAPTOP

The ritual is 20 minutes, not an evening of scrolling your own analytics. Numbers at your stage are noisy; marinating in them teaches nothing extra and invites the §01 spiral. One lesson, one banked idea, done. The loop restarts Monday at Station 1 — and you arrive rested, which is a competitive advantage disguised as a weekend.

STATION EXIT ONE LESSON WRITTEN • ONE IDEA BANKED • ACTUAL REST TAKEN. LOOP COMPLETE
— GO AGAIN.

When the loop breaks

It will. Every schedule meets a week that doesn't care about schedules. The system's real strength is its crash handling.

THE BREAK	THE MOVE
MISSED A STATION	Shrink it, never skip it. Do a 10-minute version — a 10-minute Decide (one candidate, 3-yes, pick), a 10-minute Triage (markers only on the flagged bits). A skipped station poisons every station after it; a shrunk one keeps the pipeline honest.
LOOP STRETCHED TO 18-20 DAYS	Fine. Ship it, then start a fresh 14. A stretched loop that ships is a success with a footnote. The only rule: never let a stretched loop become a paused one — the unit of survival is "the next block," not the lost days.
BRUTAL WEEK INCOMING (EXAMS, LIFE)	Declare a half-loop in advance. One Short from existing stream footage — clip, trim, captions, ship inside 3 days ↗ 1.0 §30 . The streak and the muscle survive on a fraction of the effort. Declaring it <i>in advance</i> is what makes it a strategy instead of a collapse.
TWO+ DEAD WEEKS	Re-entry protocol — Card 5 ↗ §31 . No make-up debt, smallest possible win first, half-loop before full loop. You never "start over"; skills don't reset.

THE DEADLINE TRAP — A STANDING WARNING

When life gets busy, the tempting move is fear-fuel: "*I have to grind before ___ arrives.*" You've already identified this trap — external timelines are schedule changes, not creative deadlines. Fear-based sprints produce a burst, then a crash, then the guilt spiral that kills channels. The loop's answer to a busy season is smaller loops, not desperate ones. Sustainable beats heroic over any distance that matters.

DO THIS WHEN A WEEK GOES SIDEWAYS, PICK THE ROW ABOVE THAT MATCHES AND RUN IT. NO IMPROVISING, NO GUILT.

PART 3 / 6

WHAT MAKES A GAMING VIDEO GOOD

You asked the real question: does "good" mean wall-to-wall sound effects, memes, and music? Short answer — no, and the last three years of evidence are unusually clear about it. Here's what actually holds a 13–20 audience, with receipts.

§16 THE FOUR PILLARS · §17 THE STYLE SPECTRUM · §18 SOUND DESIGN · §19 MEMES & HUMOR · §20 RETENTION BEATS



The four pillars + what YouTube optimizes now

Strip away every trend and every effect, and good gaming videos stand on the same four legs.

PILLAR	WHAT IT MEANS	THE TEST
A PREMISE, NOT A SESSION	"I'm trying to ___" beats "I played ___" every time. The premise is the reason a stranger clicks and the spine the edit hangs on.	Can you say "it's the one where ___"?
A PERSON, NOT A SCREEN	Your reaction is the product; gameplay is the setting. The biggest group-gaming channels were built on humor and personalities, not gameplay skill — the game is just where the personalities collide.	Mute the game audio — is someone still <i>there</i> ?
MOMENTUM	Every moment is building tension or paying it off ↗ 1.0 §21 . "Nothing is currently at stake" is the only unforgivable state a gaming video can be in.	Pause anywhere — is something at stake right now?
A PAYOFF THAT LANDS	Win, fail, or twist — the promise resolves, and the video ends fast afterward. Endings are where satisfaction is decided.	Does the last 30 seconds earn the first 30?

The platform context — worth knowing once

YouTube's discovery team has been unusually public about what the system optimizes now: **long-term viewer satisfaction** — how people *feel* about the time they spent — measured through direct surveys, likes and shares, and whether viewers come back. In the words of Todd Beaupré, who leads growth & discovery: they're trying to understand "not just the viewer's behavior... but how they feel about the time they're spending." Raw watch-time squeezing is explicitly not the goal; YouTube has even declined changes that would have added millions of watch hours because satisfaction suffered.

THE PRACTICAL TRANSLATION

A video someone **finishes, sends to their group chat, and comes back after** now beats a longer video people merely tolerate. Which collapses a decade of algorithm anxiety into one creative instruction: **make the video you would genuinely send to a friend**. That's not a vibe — shares, completions, and return visits are literally the measured signals. Your instinct for "addicting to watch, actually funny, not over-serious" isn't a compromise with the algorithm. It's aimed dead at what the algorithm scores.

DO THIS AT TRIAGE, GRADE THE FOOTAGE AGAINST THE FOUR PILLARS. WEAKEST PILLAR = WHERE THE EDIT WORKS HARDEST.

The style spectrum

"Not too serious, not too super polished" isn't you lowering the bar. It's you describing the current meta.

The 2020–2023 answer to "what makes gaming videos good" was *retention editing*: an effect, zoom, or sound every 1.5 seconds, engineered so leaving never gets a chance. Then the era's own architect publicly killed it:

"This past year I've slowed down our videos, focused on storytelling, let scenes breathe, yelled less, more personality, longer videos, etc. And our views have skyrocketed! My fellow YouTubers, let's get rid of the ultra fast paced/overstim era of content. It doesn't even work."

— MRBEAST, MARCH 2024 (COVERED BY THE WASHINGTON POST, TUBEFILTER, AND BASICALLY EVERYONE)

Side-by-side counts backed it up — his newer videos ran dramatically fewer cuts per minute, with longer shots and normal speaking volume. Meanwhile, the opposite pole rose: 2024–2025 saw a wave of stripped-down, barely-edited creators winning on intimacy as audiences burned out on overstimulation. The honest read of both trends together: **what died wasn't editing — it was editing as a substitute for personality.**

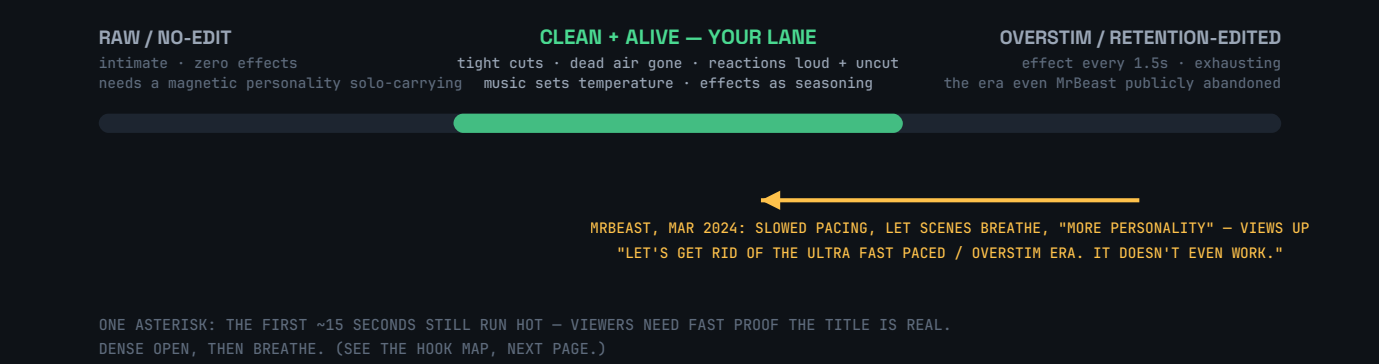


FIG 17 — THE SPECTRUM. RAW NEEDS A PERSONALITY THAT CARRIES ALONE; OVERSTIM IS DEAD; THE LANE IS CLEAN + ALIVE.

Your lane: clean + alive

- ▶ **Clean:** dead air executed on sight, tight story structure, cuts that serve pacing. This is 80% of what "well-edited" means to a viewer.
- ▶ **Alive:** reactions loud and uncut, commentary that sounds like a person, energy allowed to breathe between beats.
- ▶ **Seasoned:** effects, zooms, and SFX deployed on moments that earned them — punctuation, not wallpaper (§18).

THE ONE ASTERISK — THE OPEN STILL RUNS HOT

MrBeast's own caveat: on YouTube he still front-loads proof, because viewers arrive suspicious — *"I have this 10-second window to convince someone I actually did this."* Slow cinema starts at second 16, not second 1.

THE OPEN, MAPPED



PADDY GALLOWAY: "THE THUMBNAIL AND TITLE SELL THE CLICK. THE FIRST THIRTY SECONDS SELL THE WATCH."

FIG 17B — THE OPEN, MAPPED: DENSE PROOF → STAKES → BREATHE, WITH A BEAT EVERY ~3 MINUTES AFTER. PAIRS WITH THE HOOK FORMULA ↗ 1.0 §15.

One more thing worth saying out loud: clean + alive takes **roughly half the editing hours** of overstim style — no effect-hunting marathons, no zoom on every sentence. The current meta and your two-week loop are the same decision. That almost never happens; enjoy it.

DO THIS EDIT TO THE LANE: RUTHLESS ON DEAD AIR, GENEROUS TO REACTIONS, STINGY WITH EFFECTS. HOT OPEN, THEN BREATHE.

Sound design

SFX are punctuation. Music is temperature. Silence is the best effect you own.

The punctuation doctrine

One test decides every sound effect: **does this make the *moment* land harder — or does it just make the *video* louder?** A boom under a genuinely absurd fail is punctuation; a boom every 20 seconds is wallpaper, and wallpaper trains viewers to stop hearing your sounds entirely (then the moment that deserved one has nothing left to spend). Under-seasoned beats over-seasoned in every cuisine, including this one.

THE CORE KIT — 8 SOUNDS DO 80% OF GAMING COMEDY

- ▶ **One impact/boom** — the absurd-moment exclamation point.
- ▶ **One halt** (record scratch / tape stop) — "wait... what?"
- ▶ **One soft ding** — realizations, terrible ideas being born.
- ▶ **A whoosh family** — cuts, zooms, time skips.
- ▶ **One fail sting + one win hit** — outcomes, punctuated.
- ▶ **One tension riser** — before the door opens.
- ▶ **THE MUTE** — cutting all audio for a beat. The funniest sound in the kit costs nothing and never gets old: the drop-to-silence right before a scare or a disaster out-performs any sting you could buy.

Build a favorites folder of ≤15 sounds total. A 400-file library is a decision-fatigue machine; a 15-file kit is a language you get fluent in.

Music = emotional temperature

Music goes down *first* at Station 5 because everything above it reads differently once it exists [↗ 1.0 §11](#).

Practical rules: match the bed to the act's mood, not the whole video; duck it firmly under voice (targets in Fig 12); and choreograph at least one full **music drop-out** per video at the biggest moment — the sudden absence spikes attention harder than any addition can.

Where to get it — free, safe, current

SOURCE	WHAT	THE FINE PRINT
YOUTUBE AUDIO LIBRARY	Music + SFX, inside Studio	Designed to produce zero Content ID claims — the safest shelf on the internet for monetized long-form.
PIXABAY	Music + SFX	Free license, no attribution required. Your existing folder habit already lives here — keep going.
FREESOUND	Weird/ specific SFX	License varies <i>per file</i> — check each one (CC0 = grab freely).
TRENDING TIKTOK / CHART AUDIO	—	Claim-and-strike bait in long-form. Commercial tracks have narrow allowances inside Shorts' own audio tools, but keep them out of your long-form timeline entirely.

DO THIS THIS WEEK: BUILD THE ≤15-SOUND KIT INTO A FAVORITES FOLDER. THEN EVERY SFX DECISION TAKES FIVE SECONDS FOREVER.

Memes & humor for a 13–20 audience

The question isn't "which memes do teens like." It's "which humor still works after the meme dies."

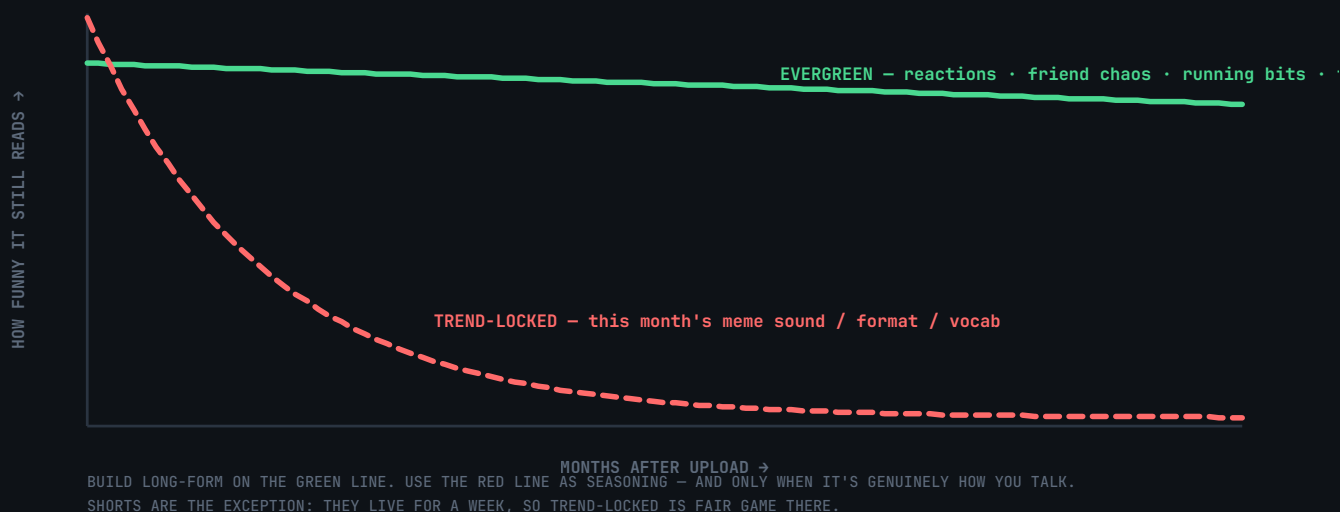


FIG 19 — THE TWO HUMOR TYPES AND HOW THEY AGE. LONG-FORM IS BUILT ON THE GREEN LINE.

Every laugh in a gaming video comes from one of two families. **Trend-locked humor** — this month's meme sound, format, or vocabulary — is genuinely funny *right now* and nearly worthless in six, because meme half-lives keep shrinking. **Evergreen humor** — genuine reactions, friend chaos, running bits, comic timing, absurd commitment to a stupid plan — was funny in 2015, is funny now, and will be funny when your audience shows their kids. One of these compounds into a channel identity. The other compounds into a time capsule.

THE MIX THAT WORKS

- ▶ **Build every long-form video on evergreen humor.** The premise, the peak, the thumbnail moment — all green-line. This is also, conveniently, the humor you already naturally produce on stream.
- ▶ **Trend-locked is seasoning, and only when it's genuinely how you talk.** A meme SFX you actually find funny, dropped once at the perfect moment: great. Forced meme vocabulary performed *at* the audience: instantly detectable, and 13–20 year-olds are the single most sensitive meme-authenticity detectors on Earth. Performed humor reads like a brand account. Nothing ages worse.
- ▶ **Your inside jokes beat the internet's inside jokes.** A running bit across YOUR videos — a recurring failure, a cursed item, a co-op partner's signature disaster — gives Core viewers callbacks [↗ 1.0 §4](#), costs nothing, and can't be copied. This is how personality-first channels turn casual viewers into people who binge the back catalog.
- ▶ **Shorts are the exception.** A Short lives hard for days and dies — trend-locked humor is fair game there, and it's actually where trends belong [↗ 1.0 §30](#).

The two tests

The 12-month test: before building anything around a meme, ask — still funny next summer? Yes → safe anywhere. No → it's a Short, not a long-form pillar. **The mirror test:** did it make *you* actually laugh? You're 13–20 adjacent and extremely online — **you are the target demo**. If it's genuinely funny to you, it's funny to them; the only fatal error is performing humor you don't personally find funny. Your sense of humor isn't something to second-guess against an imagined audience. It *is* the audience research.

DO THIS INVENT NOTHING. NOTICE WHICH BITS RECUR NATURALLY IN YOUR SESSIONS — THEN FEED THEM CALLBACKS ON PURPOSE.

Retention beats — the compact list

Everything tactical about keeping people watching, on one spread, current as of 2026.

- ▶ **A beat every ~3 minutes.** Raise stakes, callback, reveal, tonal shift, or direct address — the re-hook menu is written [↗ 1.0 §15, §7](#). Longer videos nest smaller arcs inside the main one [↗ 1.0 §23](#).
- ▶ **Dead air is the #1 small-channel edit sin.** Silence between moments reads as "nothing is happening," and per §16, that's the one unforgivable state. When in doubt, cut.
- ▶ **Micro-payoffs every 30–60 seconds.** Small question → small answer → new question. The breathing rhythm of watchable gaming content [↗ 1.0 §21](#).
- ▶ **Pattern, then break.** Establish "normal" for three beats, then violate it. Engagement spikes live at pattern breaks — it's the cheapest spike in the toolkit.
- ▶ **End ON the payoff.** Resolution lands → a breath → cut to end screen. Every second of outro past the payoff bleeds AVD, and a satisfied ending is precisely what drives the share-and-return signals the platform now scores hardest (§16). Long outros are donating your best metric to nobody.

THE CLIFF (HOOK PROBLEM)



BIG DROP BEFORE 0:30 = THE OPEN BROKE ITS PROMISE.
FIX THE FIRST 60s NEXT VIDEO — NOT THE WHOLE EDIT.

THE SLOW SLIDE → HEALTHY



GRADUAL DECLINE WITH SMALL BUMPS = BEATS LANDING.
BUMPS ARE REWATCHED MOMENTS — YOUR SHORTS LIVE THERE.

FIG 20 — THE TWO GRAPH SHAPES THAT MATTER AT THE RESET. CLIFF = FIX THE OPEN. SLOW SLIDE WITH BUMPS = WORKING.

SHORTS — THE CURRENT RULES (VERIFIED, MID-2026)

Shorts can run up to **3 minutes** (raised from 60s in October 2024; since December 2025, any vertical or square upload ≤3 min is automatically classified as a Short — worth knowing so a vertical clip never "accidentally" becomes one). But length limits aren't length advice: top-performing Shorts still cluster around **20–45 seconds**, and the punchline rule is unchanged — end on the reaction, cut immediately, nothing after [↗ 1.0 §30](#). The 3-minute ceiling is for the rare story that truly needs it, not a new target.

DO THIS AT THE RESET, MATCH YOUR RETENTION GRAPH TO A SHAPE ABOVE. THE SHAPE PICKS NEXT LOOP'S ONE LESSON FOR YOU.

PART 4 / 6

MULTI-GAME, ONE CHANNEL

You asked directly: is refusing to be tied to one game even possible on current-day gaming YouTube? Yes — it's a real strategy with a real mechanism and one honest tradeoff. This part is the answer, with evidence.

§21 THE VERDICT · §22 THE THROUGH-LINE KIT · §23 THE 10-MINUTE DEMAND CHECK



The verdict: variety is a strategy, not a compromise

Current guidance from the data-side of YouTube says it plainly: don't marry a game — chase the audience behind the games.

VidIQ's own 2025–2026 guidance for gaming channels warns that centering a channel on a single title is "not only a serious commitment but also a limiting one," and tells creators to **chase the target audience instead** — the people who love a *kind* of experience, and who follow creators across whatever games deliver it. The channels that scaled group-gaming into the tens of millions did it on **humor and group dynamics, not any one game's meta** — the games rotated for a decade; the energy never did. The unit of loyalty on gaming YouTube is the *person*, not the title.

So what actually fails? Not variety — **incoherence**. Ten games with ten different energies, ten thumbnail styles, and ten title voices gives a viewer nothing to subscribe *to*. The subscribe button is a prediction — "I know what the next one will feel like" — and incoherent channels make that prediction impossible. Variety channels don't die from playing many games. They die from being many channels.

THE MECHANISM YOU ALREADY OWN

Your bucket system [↗ 1.0 §24](#) is precisely the machine that makes variety coherent: **the angle determines the bucket, not the game** — so any title on Earth slots into horror-reactions, co-op chaos, or challenge-grind without the channel wobbling. The 8-word test proves it works: describe the channel with zero game names. "*Chaotic co-op disasters and blind horror reactions*" passes clean. If a stranger reads that and knows what they'd get — the niche exists, and no game is ever "off-brand" again.

THE HONEST TRADEOFF (SO IT NEVER SURPRISES YOU)

Single-game channels can grow *faster early* — they ride one game's search demand hard. The costs: creative burnout on repetition, and total exposure to that game's lifespan — one dead meta and the channel's reason to exist goes with it. Variety compounds slower at first because it grows on personality, but it's **antifragile**: games dying doesn't touch it, trending games feed it (§23), and it never produces the "I can't play what I want on my own channel" resentment that quietly kills solo creators. At one video per two weeks, on a multi-year horizon, personality compounding is the correct bet — and it's the one that keeps this fun, which is the actual engine of the whole system.

DO THIS WRITE YOUR 8-WORD, ZERO-GAME-NAMES CHANNEL DESCRIPTION. PIN IT IN NOTION. THAT SENTENCE IS THE NICHE.

The through-line kit

Five constants. Hold them, and any game becomes "one of yours" the moment you load into it.



FIG 22 — GAMES ORBIT. THE CORE HOLDS. THIS PICTURE IS THE ENTIRE MULTI-GAME STRATEGY.

CONSTANT	WHAT STAYS THE SAME, GAME TO GAME
01 — OPENING ENERGY	Same intro cadence and package-driven line style ↗ 1.0 §9 . Ten videos in, viewers can feel your open coming — that familiarity <i>is</i> brand.
02 — HUMOR DNA	Your evergreen bits and running callbacks (§19) travel with you. The joke engine is portable; only the scenery changes.
03 — PACKAGING LOOK	Same thumbnail face treatment, color accents, and text style; same title voice ↗ 1.0 §13-14 . The bar: a subscriber recognizes your thumbnail with the game cropped out.
04 — STRUCTURE	The arc — calm → tension → peak → payoff — is 100% game-agnostic ↗ 1.0 §23 . Viewers learn your rhythm, and rhythm is retention.
05 — RECURRING CAST	You, and the roles around you — reactor, chaos agent, straight man ↗ 1.0 §26 . Characters are the one asset no game update can patch out.

Notice what's *not* on the list: the game, the genre, even the mood. Consistency lives entirely in the wrapper. That's why a horror blind-run and a simulator grind can sit on the same channel and both be unmistakably yours — the wrapper never changed hands.

DO THIS AUDIT YOUR LAST FEW THUMBNAILS AGAINST CONSTANT 03. IF THEY COULD BE FIVE DIFFERENT CHANNELS, UNIFY THE LOOK FIRST.

Picking the next game — the 10-minute demand check

The question is never "does this fit my channel." It's "which bucket, which angle, and is anyone home?"

- 01 **Bucket + angle first (2 min).** Any game passes §21's mechanism — so the only creative question is which bucket it enters and with what angle. A cozy sim can be a chaos co-op video or a grind challenge; the angle is the decision, and it's yours.
- 02 **Autocomplete scan (3 min).** Type the game into YouTube search; every autocomplete line is a real search from a real viewer ↗ 1.0 §6 . Multiple suggestions matching your angle = demand confirmed, and often a title handed to you for free.
- 03 **Outlier scan (5 min).** Search the game, sort by recency, and look for *disproportion*: small and mid channels pulling views far above their subscriber count. That gap is the tell — it means the topic is carrying strangers to whoever posts, and it can carry you. Only mega-channels scoring? The lane may be locked to existing audiences. Nobody scoring? Demand unproven — fine for a passion pick, but know it's one. (This is the outlier method the top strategists run professionally: the growth signal lives in the anomalies, never the averages.)

TREND WINDOWS — THE ONE TIMING RULE

New horror games and viral indies have a **short, loud window** — the wave crests fast, and the creators who move inside it collect outsized views ↗ 1.0 §6 . If a trending pick fits a bucket and you can slot it into *this* loop, ride it. If the window would force a panic-loop, skip without guilt — evergreen sims, platform staples, and co-op chaos games are always open, and your channel's engine is personality, not trend-sniping. Healthy rotation: mostly always-open games, occasional trend swings. The trend brings New viewers; the identity keeps them ↗ 1.0 §4 .

DO THIS RUN THE 10-MINUTE CHECK AS PART OF STATION 1 WHENEVER THE GAME IS NEW. TEN MINUTES, THEN COMMIT — NO RESEARCH SPIRALS.

TOOLS WITHOUT THE OVERWHELM

You asked if there's other free software you should be using. The 2025–2026 landscape got checked so you don't have to: the answer is mostly "no, and that's great news." Plus the lazy-smart way to learn Resolve, and the friction kill list.

§24 THE FREE-STOCK VERDICT · §25 LEARN RESOLVE THE LAZY WAY · §26 THE FRICTION KILL LIST



The free-stack verdict

Checked against the current landscape: your stack is already the correct one. Here's the proof, then the rule.

Why DaVinci Resolve stays the main editor

The free tier of Resolve remains the anomaly of the entire industry: genuinely professional-grade, **no watermarks, no export paywalls, no subscription** — the tool doesn't degrade when you don't pay. Meanwhile the usual "easier free alternative" collapsed as a recommendation: **CapCut spent 2025 moving formerly-free features behind its Pro tier** (~\$20/month) — transitions, effects, key export options, captions among them — with widespread free-tier watermark and limit complaints, plus a June 2025 terms-of-service change granting the company sweeping rights over uploaded content that sent creators looking for exits. The "easy free editor" era of CapCut is over. You never have to migrate away from something you never migrated to.

And the deeper point: **your muscle memory is an asset that compounds**. Every loop makes Resolve faster under your hands. Switching editors resets that to zero for a tool that is, at best, sideways. The upgrade path that matters isn't new software — it's the next ten videos in the software you have.

TOOL	ROLE	VERDICT
DAVINCI RESOLVE (FREE)	The editor	Keep. Home base. Free tier covers everything the loop needs.
OBS + YOUR PLUGIN CHAIN	Capture, multi-track, vertical	Keep. Already configured and battle-tested. Touch nothing.
AFFINITY PHOTO 2	Thumbnails	Keep. Owned outright, one-time purchase — better than "free."
YT AUDIO LIBRARY + PIXABAY	Music & SFX	Keep. Free, claim-safe, already your habit (\$18).
AUDACITY	Audio surgery	<i>Optional.</i> Only if a take needs rescue beyond Fairlight — rare. Don't install preemptively.
HANDBRAKE	File compression	<i>Optional.</i> Shrinks uploads on slow internet nights. That's its whole job.
KDENLIVE	Backup editor	Fully free/open-source. Exists only as the break-glass fallback if Resolve ever stopped running on your hardware. Otherwise ignore.
CAPCUT	—	Skip. 2025 paywall shift + ToS concerns ended its free-tool status. Nothing it offers justifies restarting your muscle memory.

THE RULE THAT PROTECTS YOU FROM TOOL BRAIN

No new software until the current tool is the proven bottleneck for two loops in a row. "Proven bottleneck" means you can name the specific task the tool failed at, twice. New software *feels* like progress — fresh interface, tutorial rabbit hole, the rush of Setting Things Up — but it's usually procrastination with a download bar. The loop is the progress. The stack is done.

DO THIS CLOSE THE "BEST FREE EDITOR 2026" TABS FOREVER. THAT QUESTION IS ANSWERED ON THIS PAGE.

Learn Resolve the lazy way

You don't need a course. You need one new skill per video, forever. The math does the rest.

THE ONE-NEW-THING RULE

Each loop, learn exactly **one** new Resolve skill — chosen on purpose at Station 4 or 5, learned inside the *real edit*, never in a practice project (practice projects don't ship, so the skill doesn't stick). One per loop feels like nothing. It's ~26 skills a year — more active technique than most working editors use daily. Slow is smooth; smooth compounds.

The 90% list — the twelve operations that carry a gaming edit

#	OPERATION	WHY IT'S ON THE LIST
01	Blade + split at playhead	The cut itself. The most-pressed keys you own.
02	Ripple delete	Dead air's executioner — gap closes itself.
03	Markers + colors (M)	Your whole triage system runs on it ↗ 1.0 §17 .
04	Clip speed changes	Compress the boring, stretch the moment. Know the retime quirk below.
05	Transform (zoom / punch-in)	The reaction zoom — 80% of "edited feel" for 2% of effort.
06	Text+	Callouts, 3–5 per video. Layout tab fixes cropping.
07	Cross dissolve + fade handles	Generated titles ship with zero handle frames — fade or extend; never drag-apply and hope.
08	Audio keyframes / ducking	Music dips under voice — the difference between mixed and mush.
09	Auto-captions	Free retention from the muted majority (§20).
10	Compound clips	Group a finished bit; move it as one brick.
11	Render queue + saved preset	Export becomes one click, every time ↗ 1.0 §20 .
12	Power bins	Your SFX kit and caption style in every project, permanently.

TWO QUIRKS WORTH KNOWING COLD

- ▶ **Retime affects embedded audio only** — speed-ramping a clip won't touch audio living on its own track. Standard move: cut the audio at the ramp point and drop a music hit or SFX over the seam.
- ▶ **When stuck:** search "resolve 20 + the thing," play the tutorial at 1.5x, do it immediately inside your actual project. Fifteen minutes, skill acquired, video advanced — both at once. Stay in the Edit tab for everything that isn't color or audio repair; tab-hopping is where sessions go to die ↗ 1.0 §16 .

DO THIS AT STATION 4, WRITE THE LOOP'S "ONE NEW THING" INTO THE QUEST LOG. LEARN IT WHERE IT SHIPS.

The friction kill list

Friction you remove once is motivation you never have to summon again. Target: session start in under two minutes.

Every step between "I'll do a block" and "the timeline is in front of me" is a chance to bounce off. Most nights you don't lose to laziness — you lose to twelve tiny steps. So you delete the steps, one time, permanently:

The one-time setup (~one hour, pays out forever)

- 01 **The TEMPLATE project.** One Resolve project with everything pre-staged: 1080p60 timeline preset, bins built (Gameplay / Facecam / Audio / SFX / Music / Titles), caption power bin loaded, marker legend in a note. Every new video = duplicate template, import footage, go. **You never face a blank project again** — blank projects are where perfectionists stall hardest, because infinite options is fog (§04).
- 02 **The favorites cull.** The ≤15-sound SFX kit (§18) plus ~10 go-to music tracks, starred or in a FAVORITES bin. Browsing a huge library mid-edit is a momentum leak disguised as work.
- 03 **The export preset.** Saved once from the 1.0 settings [↗ 1.0 §20](#). Export becomes a single click, so "rendering" stops being a decision.
- 04 **The launch path.** Drive connected → Resolve → template, as few clicks as possible; shortcut on the desktop. Physical friction counts double at 11pm.
- 05 **The capture net.** One phone note (or Notion quick-capture) titled IDEAS, pinned. Ideas arrive on their schedule, not yours; a two-tap capture keeps Station 1 permanently stocked.

The 90-second end-of-session ritual (every block)

- ▶ **Write the quest line** — next block's objective, one sentence, in the project note (§05). This is the ritual's crown jewel.
- ▶ **Save.** Watch your best 20 seconds of the day. Close.

WHAT THIS BUYS YOU

Tomorrow's session now opens like this: launch → template or project opens → quest line tells you exactly what to do → timer on → editing, inside two minutes. Compare that to the default: find the drive, find the footage, stare at the timeline reconstructing your intentions, check one thing on your phone, gone. The two-minute start isn't convenience — **it's the load-bearing wall of the entire addiction loop**, because the CUE step (§05) only fires if starting is nearly free.

DO THIS SPEND ONE HOUR THIS WEEK ON THE FIVE SETUPS. IT IS THE HIGHEST-ROI HOUR IN THIS ENTIRE BOOK.

EMERGENCY CARDS

Five one-page protocols for the five ways this actually goes wrong. Written in big type for bad days. Don't read them now — know they're here, and open the right one when its moment comes.

C1 "I DON'T FEEL LIKE IT" · C2 "THIS VIDEO SUCKS" · C3 "I CAN'T PICK AN IDEA" · C4 "IT FLOPPED" · C5 "I BROKE THE STREAK"



"I don't feel like it."

For the nights the block is scheduled and the couch is winning.

- 01 Diagnose in one word — Friction, Fog, Fear, or Tired?** Ten seconds of honesty picks the fix. "Lazy" is not one of the options; lazy is not a real diagnosis [↗ §04](#).
- 02 Friction** → your only job is to *open the project*. Not edit — open. The two-minute launch (§26) does the rest more often than not.
- 03 Fog** → read the quest line. No quest line written? Then tonight's entire block IS writing one. That counts. Fill the cell.
- 04 Fear** → you are not deciding if the video is good tonight. That question is unanswerable anyway (§01). You are doing one block of one station. That's the whole contract.
- 05 Tired — actually tired** → sleep. Rest is a move inside the loop, and tomorrow's rule is only "never miss twice" (§05). Guilt is the one option with no function.
- 06 Otherwise: the 10-minute deal.** Timer on. Full legal permission to stop when it rings. Both exits fill the cell.

REMEMBER: MOTIVATION ARRIVES A FEW MINUTES AFTER STARTING. IT HAS NEVER ONCE ARRIVED BEFORE.

“This video sucks.”

For the mid-edit crisis — usually striking around the rough cut, right on schedule.

- 01 **Know the pattern: this feeling visits every edit, at this exact stage.** You've now watched these jokes fifteen times. You are the single most numb human alive to this footage — and the only one who ever will be. A viewer meets it once, fresh. **Your boredom is not data.**
- 02 **Run the two-question checkpoint.** Does the premise still make sense? Is there at least one moment you'd genuinely send to a friend? **Both yes → the video is fine.** The feeling is fatigue. Keep cutting.
- 03 **One or both no → re-angle, don't abandon.** The plan failing IS a premise — often the better one [↗ §11](#). Move the peak, flip the frame, cut the video shorter and meaner. Structural surgery is allowed. Quitting is not.
- 04 **The standing rule: no abandoning at Station 4.** Ship it or re-angle it. Every abandon trains the abandon habit; every ship trains the ship habit — you are building one of the two tonight either way. Build the right one.

A B+ VIDEO THAT EXISTS OUTRANKS AN A+ VIDEO THAT DOESN'T — IN EVERY METRIC, INCLUDING THE ONES THAT MEASURE YOU.

"I can't pick an idea."

For Station 1 paralysis — five candidates, zero commitment, three days gone.

- 01 **Rename the problem.** You are not out of ideas — the notes app is full. You are out of *decisions*. Different problem, different fix: a timer. Fifteen minutes, starting now.
- 02 **Two candidates only.** Last stream's best moment + the top of the idea bank. Comparing five options is how deciding became three days in the first place.
- 03 **Run the 3-yes test on both** [↗ §08](#). One passes → locked. Done. Close the app.
- 04 **Neither passes → sharpen the closer one, twice.** Add a restriction, a timer, or a consequence [↗ 1.0 §1.5](#). Two sharpening passes rescue most "meh" ideas.
- 05 **Still nothing → schedule a blind Discovery session** on whatever's next in rotation, and mine it afterward. Recording generates ideas. Waiting generates waiting.
- 06 **When the timer rings, the leading candidate wins.** Non-negotiable. A shipped B-idea teaches you more than an unshipped A-idea ever will — and per §01, you can't actually tell which is which from here anyway.

THE BEST IDEA IS UNKNOWABLE IN ADVANCE. THE DECIDED IDEA IS AVAILABLE RIGHT NOW.

"It flopped."

For the upload that went out and did... nothing. Read 48 hours after, not 4 hours after.

- 01 **Feel it for one day.** Allowed and normal. Cap it at one.
- 02 **Then reclassify: it's a data point now.** Run the diagnostic — CTR low, retention fine → packaging. CTR fine, early cliff → the first 60 seconds. Both low → concept
↗ 1.0 §7, §20 . Write the ONE lesson.
- 03 **Price the damage honestly: ≈ zero.** Nobody unsubscribed from a channel they haven't found yet. A flop at your stage costs nothing and pays out a full lesson — objectively the best trade on the platform, available exclusively to small channels. It stops being free later. Use it now.
- 04 **Think like the strategists: the signal lives in outliers.** Videos far above OR below your baseline are where the information is; averages teach nothing. A flop just narrowed your next bet for free.
- 05 **Next loop starts at Station 1, on schedule.** Same system, sharper inputs. The creators who make it aren't the ones who never flop — they're the ones whose loop doesn't care.

EVERY VIDEO IS A DATA POINT, NOT A REPORT CARD. THE 30TH IS BUILT FROM THE LESSONS OF THE FIRST 29.

"I broke the streak."

For the return after two dead weeks — or two dead months. The re-entry protocol.

- 01 **Zero make-up work. Rule one, non-negotiable.** "I need to catch up" is the exact thought that keeps people from ever coming back — the imaginary debt grows until re-entry feels impossible. There is no debt. The archive doesn't judge. The loop simply restarts.
- 02 **Today: the smallest possible win.** One 10-minute block — open the project, or watch flagged footage, or write one title. Momentum first. Ambition is next week's business.
- 03 **First loop back = a declared half-loop.** One Short from existing stream footage, shipped inside three days ↗ §15, 1.0 §30 . Small, fast, real — the muscle wakes up on a win.
- 04 **Then a normal 14-day loop.** Full size, no penance pace, no "making up for lost time" sprint — that's the deadline trap wearing a comeback costume ↗ §15 .
- 05 **Say the true sentence: you never started over.** Skills don't reset. Twelve videos of muscle memory survived the break completely intact. The counter paused; it never went down.

CONSISTENCY ISN'T NEVER STOPPING. IT'S HOW CHEAPLY YOU RESTART. THIS CARD MAKES RESTARTING COST TEN MINUTES.

The loop on one page

THE SIX STATIONS

- ▶ **D1 — DECIDE:** 3-yes test · 3 titles · thumbnail sentence · package. One block, timer on.
- ▶ **D2-3 — RECORD:** preflight · intro line · 3 anchors · live markers · hot-take voice note.
- ▶ **D4 — TRIAGE:** no-edit watch at 2x · 4 timestamps · lock the title · "it's the one where ____."
- ▶ **D5-8 — STORY CUT:** peak to the front · cut to the 4 points · zero polish · boring test.
- ▶ **D9-10 — ENERGY:** music → SFX → text → captions, as separate passes · mix to targets.
- ▶ **D11-12 — SHIP:** one watch · export · thumbnail while rendering · SCHEDULE.
- ▶ **D13-14 — RESET:** 20 min on last video's data · ONE lesson · bank next idea · rest.

THE B+ CHECKLIST = DONE

- ▶ Premise unmistakable in 30 seconds
- ▶ Dead air gone — boring test passed
- ▶ Audio on targets · one clean full playback
- ▶ 3+ moments that still get a reaction from you
- ▶ Title + thumbnail pass the glance test

THE MIX, MEMORIZED

VOICE -12 → -10 dB
 SFX -12 → -8 dB
 GAME -18 → -16 dB
 MUSIC -20 → -18 dB
 WHOLE -14 LUFS · PEAK -1 dBTP

THE BLOCK RULES

- ▶ A block = 25-45 min, ONE named objective
- ▶ Never end a block without writing the next quest line
- ▶ End every session on your best 20 seconds
- ▶ One block a day keeps the streak — any block
- ▶ **Never miss twice.** After a miss: smallest block possible

THE STANDING LAWS

- ▶ "Why would anyone watch this?" is unanswerable — ask "would I click it?" instead
- ▶ Real idea + you in it = a version, never slop
- ▶ No polish before structure locks
- ▶ No abandoning at Station 4 — ship or re-angle
- ▶ Doubt at the schedule button predicts nothing
- ▶ One new Resolve skill per loop, learned in the real edit
- ▶ No new software until a tool bottlenecks two loops straight

THE STYLE LANE

Clean + alive: ruthless on dead air, generous to reactions, stingy with effects. Hot proof-first open (0-15s), then breathe, a beat every ~3 min, end ON the payoff. Evergreen humor is the build; memes are seasoning; silence is the best SFX you own.

EMERGENCIES

DON'T FEEL LIKE IT → CARD 1
 VIDEO SUCKS (MID-EDIT) → CARD 2
 CAN'T PICK AN IDEA → CARD 3
 IT FLOPPED → CARD 4
 WEEKS OFF → CARD 5

SCREENSHOT THIS PAGE. IT IS THE WHOLE SYSTEM AT ARM'S LENGTH.

The first-ten tracker

Ten loops. One row each. Fill a cell when a station completes — the filling is the mechanic, the medium is whatever you'll actually touch (paper, Notion, screenshot markup).

VIDEO	DECIDE	RECORD	TRIAGE	CUT	ENERGY	SHIP ★	THE ONE LESSON
01							
02							
03							
04							
05							
06							
07							
08							
09							
10							

WHAT TEN ROWS ACTUALLY BUYS

Ten shipped videos ≈ five months at the loop's pace — and per Part 1, ten full reps through every skill in the stack, ten retention graphs read, ten one-line lessons applied. The creator who finishes row 10 is not the creator who started row 1, and that difference was purchased entirely with B+ videos that exist. When the grid is full, print another. That's the whole career, actually.

Receipts

You fact-check things — good. Here's where the load-bearing claims in this book come from, so you can check them too.

- ▶ **MrBeast ending the overstim era** — his March 2024 public statement ("slowed down our videos... let scenes breathe... let's get rid of the ultra fast paced/overstim era, it doesn't even work"), covered by The Washington Post and Tubefilter, including cut-count comparisons of his old vs. new videos. His "10-second window to prove the title is real" caveat is from his Beast Games press interviews. [WASHINGTONPOST.COM](https://www.washingtonpost.com) · [TUBEFILTER.COM](https://www.tubefilter.com)
- ▶ **YouTube optimizing viewer satisfaction over raw watch time** — Todd Beaupré (YouTube Senior Director of Growth & Discovery), on Creator Insider and in interviews with YouTube's Creator Liaison: satisfaction measured via surveys, engagement, and long-term return; YouTube has declined watch-time-boosting changes that hurt satisfaction. [CREATOR INSIDER \(YOUTUBE\)](https://creatorinsider.youtube.com) · [VIDIQ.COM](https://vidiq.com) · [BUFFER.COM](https://buffer.com)
- ▶ **Shorts rules** — max length raised to 3 minutes on Oct 15, 2024; since Dec 8, 2025, vertical/square uploads ≤3 min are classified as Shorts; YouTube Audio Library music is claim-free by design. [SUPPORT.GOOGLE.COM/YOUTUBE](https://support.google.com/youtube) (OFFICIAL HELP)
- ▶ **The "inauthentic content" line** — YouTube's July 2025 monetization policy update targeting mass-produced, repetitious content while protecting original human-made videos. [YOUTUBE HELP](https://www.youtube.com/help) · [TUBEBUDDY.COM COVERAGE](https://tubebuddy.com/coverage)
- ▶ **Paddy Galloway on reps, packaging, and outliers** — the 95/5 vs 30% time-allocation finding, the astrophotographer packaging case, "the thumbnail and title sell the click, the first thirty seconds sell the watch," reps-first for beginners, and outlier-based research; from his Colin & Samir and Creator Science appearances (2024–2025). [COLINANDSAMIR.COM](https://colinandsamir.com) · [CREATORSCIENCE.COM](https://creatorscience.com)
- ▶ **Variety-channel guidance** — VidIQ's gaming-channel guides: chase the audience behind the games rather than one title; channel examples that rotate games around a stable core. Group-channel precedent (humor/dynamics over gameplay) per long-running channel analyses. [VIDIQ.COM](https://vidiq.com)
- ▶ **The no-edit / authenticity wave** — 2024 reporting on audiences fatiguing of retention-edited content and stripped-down creators rising. [ROLLING STONE](https://www.rollingstone.com) (AUG 2024)
- ▶ **CapCut's 2025 shift** — formerly-free features moved behind Pro (~\$20/mo), free-tier watermarks/limits, and the June 2025 ToS change granting broad content rights; widely reported across creator-tool coverage. [MULTIPLE 2025-26 TOOL REVIEWS & CREATOR REPORTS](#)
- ▶ **The taste-gap idea** — Ira Glass's well-known "the gap" monologue on beginner taste outrunning beginner skill, closed only by volume of finished work. [IRA GLASS](#), "THE GAP"

SHELF LIFE

Numbers and platform rules above were verified as of **July 2026**. Platform mechanics drift — when a claim matters for a real decision, the tiebreaker is always YouTube's official Help pages, not this book and not a random 2023 tutorial. The psychology in Part 1 and the loop in Part 2, though — those don't expire.

END OF BIBLE 2.0 — THE SYSTEM. PICK A GAME. RUN STATION 1. THE LOOP STARTS WHEN YOU DO. ■